



THIRD DIMENSION: Third Front leaders change the dynamics of the race by propping up Kalam's name as the joint Opposition candidate

colleagues. But even before Naidu and friends could reach their next destination—the CPI headquarters four km away—the politburo issued a terse statement, which said: “The CPI(M) has already decided to extend support to UPA nominee Pratibha Patil. In view of this, the matter cannot be considered.” The reaction at their next stop was equally predictable. CPI general secretary A.B. Bardhan gave a patient hearing to the Front leaders but later politely declined to consider Kalam's name for the elections. DMK chief and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi poured scorn on the Third Front, saying “it was indecent on the part of the Third Front to propose Kalam's name for a second term”.

It had become clear to the Front that they could not get the Left leaders to negotiate with the Congress on Kalam. Then followed one-on-one meetings with NCP president Sharad Pawar and Samajwadi Party general secretary Amar Singh and telephonic calls with, among others, NDA convenor

George Fernandes. Third Front leaders point out that the exercise was not mere posturing.

The numbers are on the UPA's side. With 5.74 lakh votes, the UPA-Left-BSP

camp has crossed the requisite halfway mark of 5.50 lakh. The NDA has 3.56 lakh votes while the born-again Third Front, going by its latest nomenclature of United National Progressive Alliance, has 1.05 lakh votes. In addition, there is a block of 63,000 floating

votes which consist of parties such as the Jan Morcha, Gorkha National Liberation Front, National Loktantrik Party etc. Even if the entire Opposition joins forces, it cannot dent the UPA's margin of over 24,000 votes. For now, the UPA allies are standing firm and have filed their nomination papers for

Patil. For once, the Left is their safest bet. The communists had opposed Kalam's candidature in 2002 and instead pitted their own candidate Captain Lakshmi Sahgal against him. Despite Kalam's Tamil credentials, the DMK is wary of supporting a candidate

propped by arch rival AIADMK chief J. Jayalalithaa. Apart from numerical support, Karunanidhi has also given 'literary' support to Patil, penning a poem exhorting her to break the gender barrier. What also helps is that an NDA ally, the Shiv Sena, has made its dis-

pleasure of Kalam's presidency well known. In addition, Patil is a Maharashtrian. Sena chief Bal Thackeray has indicated that he is willing to throw his support base of 21,000 votes in favour of 'the Rashtrapatni'. This is not the first time that regional compulsions have been factored in.

**THE UPA-LEFT-BSP
COMBINE CROSSES
THE HALFWAY MARK,
BUT SECRET BALLOT
MEANS NOTHING IS
TAKEN FOR GRANTED.**